

Westhampton Ag Commission

Minutes of the Meeting
Thursday July 15, 2026, 7:00 PM

Approved

8-20-26

Steve Holt

Called to order at 7:00 PM

Present: Steve Holt, Austin Norris and Richard I. Tracy.

First order of business is to reorganize. Moved by Tracy and Seconded by Norris that Holt be chairman. So voted.

Moved by Holt and Seconded by Norris that Tracy be clerk. So voted.

Holt read the notice from the Selectboard asking that the Ag. Commission consider the complaint about agricultural activity on Main Rd. Assessors parcel 29-9-61B. Holt noted that the Ag. Commission has only an advisory role and has no regulatory power.

Aaron Bauer, the landowner, presented that land is in Chapter 61A and 61B with 20 acres in hay land and an approved Forestry plan for the wooded portion.

Steven Cowley and Caroline Hollady made a brief presentation about their farming activities. They farm 160 acres in Southampton and raise beef, lamb, poultry and hay. They also rent hayland from Mr. Bauer. They are an organic farm and use manure as fertilizer. Mr. Cowley made 3 main points:

1. Soil health. He believes there are benefits of manure vs. chemical fertilizer including increasing the soil organic matter. The manure in question is from an certified organic farm.
2. Water quality. The slower release of nutrients means they are less likely to leach away and the increased organic matter improves water retention and reduces runoff. It was noted that a representative from Holyoke Water Works viewed the and said the activity was in n O.k. area.
3. Odor. There is no debate that poultry manure has an unpleasant odor. The anticipated rainfall did not occur after the manure was spread to help dissipate the odor.



For the specific activity in question, 25 tons of poultry manure were delivered Tuesday June 2, 2026 and were spread Friday and Saturday June 5 and 6, 2026 at an approximate rate of 1 ton per acre.

Comments and questions from the floor were taken.

-C. Reid raised concerns about the dust while spreading. Would like to know in advance before spreading in the future.

-J. Kahane raised concerns about disease issues and wondered about cow vs. poultry manure. Cowley noted it is not practical to transport and spread cattle manure from his farm in Southampton.

-M. Stacey raised concerns about legal activity in water overly.

There was some general discussion on the floor about overlays and zones and the select and planning boards. Concerns were raised about private well contamination.

Bauer noted his well is several hundred feet deep and doubted that ground water would move that deep. Also noted that the surface water all moves towards the Manhan River and Matt Smith from H.W.W. inspected the site and did not see a problem from their perspective.

-Reid thought that manure has a slower release and is less likely to leach and is a safe alternative. Cowley noted his spreading rate is about 1 ton per acre and leaching is a problem only if manure is over applied or spread in winter.

-Kahane had continued concerns about the overlay and thinks is more complicated than a simple yes or no. He also had concerns about the pile being dumped near the road when delivered.

--Stacey stated he just wants to be sure about the law and safety. Also odors were a problem for 5 days.

Cowley noted that the DEP referred him to the HWW as noted above.

-Bauer noted that next year the delivery will be made to a different spot and he wants to work with the neighbors.

-Stacey asked if the nuisance law was red into the Selectmens minutes.

The commission will consider the input received and try to do more research for our next meeting on August 20, 2026 at 7:00 PM at the Town Hall.

Moved by Norris and seconded by Tracy to adjourn. So voted. 7:52 PM
Respectfully, Richard I. Tracy, Clerk